

Ipek Naz Obek

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EDUCATION

University of Pennsylvania, College of Arts & Sciences | Philadelphia, PA **May 2025**

B.A., Cognitive Science, Data Science, Computational Neuroscience

Summa Cum Laude | *Distinction in Cognitive Science* | *Benjamin Franklin Scholar* | *Certificate in French*

Honors Thesis: *Inferring Level Progress in Goal-Directed and Open-Ended Tasks*

Advisors: Alison Gopnik, Sharon Thompson-Schill, Annya Dahmani

Relevant Coursework: Programming Languages, Probability, Data Mining, Statistical Inference, Calculus I & II, Linear Algebra, Cognitive & Computational Neuroscience, Judgment & Decisions, Behavioral Economics, Developmental Psychology

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Computation, Learning, and Development Lab, *Research Technician and Lab Manager* | Boston, MA **August 2025 - Present**

PI: Dr. Kate Nussenbaum

- Lead the design and implementation of online behavioral studies investigating goal pursuit strategies and persistence in children, adolescents, and adults.
- Design and program browser-based behavioral experiments using jsPsych, PsychoPy, and Qualtrics.
- Analyze trial-level behavioral data using mixed-effects models in R to characterize developmental and individual differences in learning and choice.
- Implement computational models of sequential decision-making to test competing accounts of human exploration and value-guided learning in Python.
- As the lab's first lab manager, established experimental, recruitment, and data-collection infrastructure, recruiting over 1,000 participants into the lab's database for developmental studies.
- Organized biweekly multi-lab journal club bringing together researchers to discuss different research papers.

Thompson-Schill & Jenkins Lab, *Research Assistant* | Philadelphia, PA

January 2024 – May 2025

PIs: Dr. Sharon Thompson-Schill, Dr. Anna Jenkins

- Conducted honors thesis research, jointly advised across the Thompson-Schill and Gopnik Labs, on human and AI representations of learning progress in goal-directed and open-ended environments.
- Participated in weekly joint lab meetings, discussing current research and literature with faculty and lab members.

Gopnik Cognitive Development and Learning Lab, *Research Assistant* | Berkeley, CA

June 2024 – May 2025

PI: Dr. Alison Gopnik, Advisors: Annya Dahmani

- Designed a novel behavioral paradigm using Progen environments to investigate how people infer learning progress in goal-directed and open-ended tasks.
- Developed computational accounts of learning-progress inference and compared human judgments with reinforcement-learning agents and large language models.
- Designed and analyzed experiments examining how people construct and evaluate curricula for complex, multi-step tasks.
- Supported by the Pinkel Research Fund, Benjamin Franklin Research Grant, and Career Services Research Grant; received the Benjamin Franklin Talk Prize.
- Recruited families on-site and conducted in-person behavioral testing with children in a museum setting, administering experimental protocols and collecting developmental data.

Center for Neuroengineering and Therapeutics, *Research Assistant* | Philadelphia, PA

June 2023 – September 2023

PI: Dr. Brian Litt, Advisors: Dr. James Guggler

- Investigated relationships between traumatic-brain-injury lesion characteristics and subsequent post-traumatic epilepsy using multimodal neuroimaging data.
- Developed Python-based quantitative and machine-learning analyses relating lesion volume and location to clinical outcomes.
- Built an automated pipeline for MRI lesion segmentation and volumetric analysis, reducing reliance on manual annotation workflows.

MANUSCRIPTS & WORK IN PROGRESS

Obek, I., Dahmani, A., & Gopnik, A. (in preparation). *Level Learning Progress*.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

- **Obek, I. N., Dahmani, A., & Gopnik, A.** (2024, September). *Automated curriculum learning in children and machines* [Poster]. Penn National Research Conference, Philadelphia, PA.
- **Obek, I. N., Gugger, J., Narang, S., Vasireddy, M., & Zhao, C.** (2023, August). *Understanding the link between TBI-induced lesions and epilepsy* [Poster]. MindCORE Research Fellowship Conference, Philadelphia, PA.
- **Obek, I. N., Dahmani, A., & Gopnik, A.** (2025, October). *Automated curriculum learning in children and machines* [Poster]. Curiosity, Information Seeking, And Exploration. Brown University, Providence, RI.
- **Obek, I. N., Dahmani, A., & Gopnik, A.** (2025, October). *Automated curriculum learning in children and machines* [Video]. Big Team Science Conference.
- **Obek, I. N., Holton, E., & Nussenbaum, K.** (2026, September). *Examining the Development of Goal Commitment* [Poster]. Flux Congress, La Jolla, CA.

HONORS & AWARDS

Distinction in Cognitive Science Awarded for completing an honors thesis and demonstrating academic excellence in the major.	May 2025
Pinkel Research Fund Funding awarded to support senior honors thesis on curriculum learning in humans and machines.	March 2025
Benjamin Franklin Talk Prize Winner Recognized for the best senior research presentation among the 2025 Benjamin Franklin Scholars cohort.	April 2025
Benjamin Franklin Research Grant Awarded summer research funding by the Benjamin Franklin Scholars Program.	March 2024
Career Services Research Grant Competitive research funding awarded by Penn Career Services.	March 2024
Lucid Communication Challenge – Engineering and Physical Sciences Talk Selected from a field of applications at the National Research Conference at Penn to present my honors thesis.	October 2024
Undergraduate Research Mentoring Award Awarded fellowship through Penn’s Undergraduate Research Mentoring Program.	May 2023
MindCORE Fellowship Selected for a fully funded 10-week summer research program in cognitive science and neuroscience.	May 2023
Dean’s List Awarded with a GPA of 3.7 or higher.	2021 - 2025

TEACHING & MENTORING

Undergraduate Program in Neuroscience, Teaching Assistant Philadelphia, PA	September 2024 – May 2025
• Teaching Assistant for Dr. Sharon Thompson-Schill’s undergraduate neuroscience course; supported students through weekly office hours, in-class instruction, group activities, and individualized academic guidance.	
Benjamin Franklin Scholars Mentor Program, Peer Mentor Philadelphia, PA	September 2024 – May 2025
• Mentored 7 Benjamin Franklin Scholars in their academic and social transition to Penn through regular individual outreach and community-building events.	
Center for Undergraduate Research and Fellowships, Research Peer Advisor Philadelphia, PA	September 2024 – May 2025
• Mentored undergraduates pursuing research opportunities and organized research programming, including an international faculty symposium on the experiences and challenges of international academics.	
Undergraduate Program in Cognitive Science, Teaching Assistant Philadelphia, PA	September 2023 – December 2023
• Led weekly recitations and office hours for 20+ students, developing instructional materials and guiding students through course concepts and assignments.	
Weingarten Tutoring Center, Tutor Philadelphia, PA	September 2022 – December 2022
• Tutored first-year students in Calculus II for 4 hours per week, providing individualized support with mathematical problem-solving and study strategies.	

ACADEMIC LEADERSHIP & SERVICE

Cognitive Science Student Association, Founder & President Philadelphia, PA	September 2024 – May 2025
• Founded and led Penn’s Cognitive Science Student Association, organizing faculty talks, research seminars, mentoring, and networking initiatives connecting students with faculty, alumni, and industry professionals.	
The DREAM Program, Recruitment Chair Philadelphia, PA	October 2023 – May 2025
• Led volunteer recruitment and weekly educational programming for preschool-aged children in West Philadelphia, including hands-on science activities designed to foster curiosity, collaboration, and confidence in learning.	
Turkish Student Association, President Philadelphia, PA	September 2022 – May 2025
• Directed a 50-member organization and community initiatives, including raising \$8K for earthquake-relief efforts.	

- Pioneer Academics**, *Program Coordinator and Advisory Board Member* | Philadelphia, PA *June 2022 – August 2025*
- Advised 100+ students through the research and writing process and coordinated research seminars focused on effective research practices and faculty mentorship.
- Assembly of International Students**, *Social Committee Member* | Philadelphia, PA *September 2021 – May 2025*
- Organized social and cultural programming to foster community among Penn's international student population.
- The Daily Pennsylvanian**, *Photographer* | Philadelphia, PA *September 2021 – May 2025*
- Photographed campus events and contributed visual content for multimedia stories at Penn's student newspaper.
- Young Guru Academy**, *Alumni Mentor* *2019 - Present*
- Mentor Turkish high school and university students pursuing international education and STEM careers; led STEM outreach across 5+ cities in rural Anatolia, training teachers and students and delivering hands-on science education to underserved communities; and [presented](#) at YGA's annual summit to ~20,000 attendees.

SKILLS

Programming:

Python, R, JavaScript, MATLAB, SQL, Java, OCaml

Research Tools & Platforms:

jsPsych, Qualtrics, Prolific, Git/GitHub, Jupyter, LaTeX, AFNI

Certifications:

CITI Training: Biomedical Responsible Conduct of Research, Human Subjects Research, Social-Behavioral Research with Children

Languages:

English (fluent), Turkish (native), French (fluent)

REFERENCES

- Kate Nussenbaum
Assistant Professor
Department of Psychological and Brain Sciences
Boston University
e-mail: katenuss@bu.edu
- Alison Gopnik
Professor of Psychology
Department of Psychology
University of California, Berkeley
e-mail: gopnik@berkeley.edu
- Annya Dahmani
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University of California, Berkeley
Advised by Alison Gopnik
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- Sharon Thompson-Schill
Christopher H. Browne Distinguished Professor of Psychology
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- Russell Richie
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